

Persecution, however, was not the only item on the SRV government's list of punishments. Between 1975 and 1980, more than one million North Vietnamese citizens were sent to live in the south and central regions of the former South Vietnam, apparently to balance the population. Meanwhile, up to one million South Vietnamese people were relocated, and families were moved to previously uninhabited areas in the mountains called New Economic Zones. Estimates vary, but suggest that between 20,000 and 155,000 South Vietnamese people died performing hard labor in situations that were described by eyewitnesses both as "prefabricated hell" and "place[s] one comes to only if the alternative to it would be death."

Seeking asylum

Unsurprisingly, many former South Vietnamese people chose not to remain under the new regime. After the communist takeover, two million people fled Vietnam by boat. These refugees, who became known as the "boat people," risked their lives to escape. Even the most fortunate of them had horrendous experiences—hunger, thirst, pirate attacks, and rape—but the lucky ones made it to UN camps, before migrating to countries such as Canada, Australia, and the US.

70 PERCENT of boat people died at sea, according to SRV sources. Other estimates are lower—around 50 percent.